

Translating the Science of Purpose in Life

A course on purpose research and its translation into practice

INSTRUCTORS

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CREDITS

3

CLASS LOCATION

Fernow Hall, G24

CLASS SCHEDULE

Mondays & Wednesdays, 2:55–4:10pm

OFFICE HOURS

By appointment

Course Description

In recent years scholars have produced an abundance of research demonstrating the potential impact of having a sense of purpose in life. From increased psychological well-being and net worth to decreased risk of mortality, there is evidence that purpose is related to outcomes that matter to most people. Though these findings are well-documented in the empirical literature, there is a need for people to work with individuals and communities outside of academia to translate existing research into applications that are practical, relevant, and accessible.

The primary aim of this course is to offer students an introduction to the science of purpose with the goal of being able to share this knowledge and co-create new knowledge with communities that might benefit from it. Students will be supported in developing skills for communicating about research with groups and individuals that might apply relevant findings in their own lives, organizations, and/or communities. Though our focus will be on translating the science of purpose in life in particular, we anticipate that these skills will be applicable for communicating about other types of research as well.

Course Objectives

Throughout this course, students will have opportunities to:

- Identify different approaches to defining and measuring purpose commonly used by researchers
- Articulate how purpose is linked to various outcomes and evaluate cultural and societal factors that influence the pursuit of purpose
- Develop effective communication strategies for conveying the science of purpose to different audiences
- Implement skills for communicating across differences in background, position, and perspective to generate potential applications of purpose-related findings

- Apply the science of purpose to practical situations, such as program development, enhancing youth learning or engagement, or deepening employee satisfaction and retention

Course Format & Grading

20%

**ATTENDANCE &
PARTICIPATION**

25%

DAILY REFLECTIONS

30%

**CORNERSTONE
PROJECTS**

25%

**FINAL PRESENTATION
& PAPER**

Attendance and participation in weekly class sessions (20%): We recognize a variety of ways that individuals can contribute to this course, including meaningful input, adherence to our community agreements, and thoughtful engagement with course readings. Because much of this class is about developing skills for communicating and collaborating, you will get more out of the experience if you attend class and participate in the conversations.

Daily Reflections (25%): Written reflections are brief questions or comments students submit to engage with presented material or in-class discussions. For each class session they attend, students can submit one written reflection. The prompt will be available on Canvas; reflections must be submitted by 10pm. To earn the full 25%, each student is expected to submit a minimum of 15 daily reflections. It is the students' responsibility to submit these reflections.

Cornerstone Projects (30%): Students will be introduced to and engage with three different organizations working to support purpose inquiry, development, or translation. Each student will (1) analyze the organizations' goals and challenges using course concepts, (2) contribute a concrete, actionable insight or solution, and (3) participate in guided reflection, evaluating what it means to translate the science of purpose into practice.

Final Presentation & Paper (25%): Each student will select one of their cornerstone project actionable insights/solutions and, following a peer feedback process, deliver a brief in-class presentation and submit a paper that clearly describes the recommendation, conveys its relevance to both the organization and existing research on purpose in life, and reflects on the process of giving and receiving peer feedback. **Final paper due 11:59pm on May 16, 2026.**

Course Logistics

- We support an inclusive learning environment where diversity and individual differences are respected, appreciated, and recognized as a source of strength. We expect students in this class to respect differences and to demonstrate diligence in understanding how others' perspectives, behaviors, and worldviews may be different from their own.
- Canvas will be an essential resource for students in this course — the syllabus, readings, written reflection assignments, and announcements will be shared on our course's Canvas page.
- You will get out of this course what you put into it. Each student is expected to abide by the Cornell University Code of Academic Integrity. Violations of the Code, especially plagiarism, may result in a failing grade in the course. Students are urged to read and complete the exercises on "Recognizing and Avoiding Plagiarism" at plagiarism.arts.cornell.edu/tutorial.
- Our aim is for you to leave this course with new knowledge and skills. In-class activities and written assignments are designed to help you process and understand the course material, but also to

help us gauge what you've learned. If you choose to use generative AI when working on any assignments for this course, we hope that you'll do so in a way that is supportive to your learning.

Accommodations

We are committed to providing equal educational opportunities to all students.

- If you have a documented disability, please provide us with a copy of your Student Disability Services (SDS) accommodation letter early in the course so that we have adequate time to arrange your approved academic accommodations.
- If you need an immediate accommodation, please speak with us after class or send an email message to us and/or SDS at sds_cu@cornell.edu.
- Your access in this course is important to us, and some aspects of this course may be modified to facilitate your participation and progress. If you experience any access barriers, please reach out to us or your SDS counselor right away.
- If the need arises for additional accommodations during the semester, please contact SDS — Level 5 of Cornell Health, 110 Ho Plaza, 607-254-4545, sds.cornell.edu.

Weekly Overview

Week 1 Introducing the Course

Jan. 21 · No preparation required

Week 2 Understanding Research & Translational Research

Jan. 26 & Jan. 28

FOR MONDAY

- Stone, E. (2016, October). Academic research is publicly funded — why isn't it publicly available? [Video]. TED Conferences.

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Burrow, A. L. (2023). Beyond finding purpose: Motivating a translational science of purpose acquisition. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 20(12), 6091.
- Austin, C. P. (2021). Opportunities and challenges in translational science. *Clinical and Translational Science*, 14(5), 1629–1647.

Week 3 Defining Purpose

Feb. 2 & Feb. 4

FOR MONDAY

- McKnight, P. E., & Kashdan, T. B. (2009). Purpose in life as a system that creates and sustains health and well-being. *Review of General Psychology, 13*(3), 242–251.
- Damon, W., Menon, J., & Bronk, K. C. (2003). The development of purpose during adolescence. *Applied Developmental Science, 7*(3), 119–128.

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Bronk, K. C., & Damon, W. (2021). What makes a purpose "worth having"? Commentary on Burrow, Agans, Jeon, and Creim. *Human Development, 65*(2), 113–117.
- Hill, P. L., & Pfund, G. N. (2022). Purpose should be in the eye of the holder, not the researcher. *Human Development, 66*(3), 216–218.

Week 4 Sense of Purpose and Its Correlates

Feb. 9 & Feb. 11

FOR MONDAY

- Hill, P. L., Turiano, N. A., Mroczek, D. K., & Burrow, A. L. (2016). The value of a purposeful life: Sense of purpose predicts greater income and net worth. *Journal of Research in Personality, 65*, 38–42.
- Kim, E. S., Chen, Y., Nakamura, J. S., Ryff, C. D., & VanderWeele, T. J. (2022). Sense of purpose in life and subsequent physical, behavioral, and psychosocial health. *American Journal of Health Promotion, 36*(1), 137–147.
- Ryff, C. D., & Kim, E. S. (2020). Extending research linking purpose in life to health. *The Ecology of Purposeful Living across the Lifespan, 29–58*.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #1: IN-CLASS PARTNER CONVERSATION WITH PSIX

- Burrow, A. L., Hill, P. L., Stanley, M., & Sumner, R. (2024). The role of purpose in the stress process: A homeostatic account. *Journal of Research in Personality, 108*, 104444.
- Kashdan, T. B., & McKnight, P. E. (2013). Commitment to a purpose in life: An antidote to the suffering by individuals with social anxiety disorder. *Emotion, 13*(6), 1150.

Week 5 Purpose Exploration

Feb. 18

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Hill, P. L., Sumner, R., & Burrow, A. L. (2014). Understanding the pathways to purpose. *The Journal of Positive Psychology, 9*(3), 227–234.
- Bronk, K. C., Hill, P. L., Lapsley, D. K., Talib, T. L., & Finch, H. (2009). Purpose, hope, and life satisfaction in three age groups. *The Journal of Positive Psychology, 4*(6), 500–510.

Cornerstone Project #1 (PSIX) Organizational Analysis due 11:59pm

Week 6 Purpose Content

Feb. 23 & Feb. 25

FOR MONDAY

- Hill, P. L., Burrow, A. L., Brandenberger, J. W., Lapsley, D. K., & Quaranto, J. C. (2010). Collegiate purpose orientations and well-being in early and middle adulthood. *Journal of Applied Developmental Psychology*, 31(2), 173–179.
- Burrow, A. L., Agans, J. P., Jeon, H. J., & Creim, M. (2021). Are all purposes worth having? Integrating content and strength in purpose research. *Human Development*, 65(2), 100–112.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #1 (PSIX): IN-CLASS COLLECTIVE REFLECTION

- Wolk, M. W., Strecher, V. J., & Hill, P. L. (2024). Considering the wellbeing correlates of activist purpose. *Journal of Happiness Studies*, 25(7), 108.

Cornerstone Project #1 (PSIX): Actionable contribution due 11:59pm

Week 7 Contexts That Influence Purpose Development

March 2 & March 4

FOR MONDAY

- Sumner, R., Burrow, A. L., & Hill, P. L. (2018). The development of purpose in life among adolescents who experience marginalization. *American Psychologist*, 73(6), 740–752.
- Shamah, D., & MacTavish, K. A. (2018). Purpose and perceptions of family social location among rural youth. *Youth & Society*, 50(1), 26–48.

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Xi, J., Lee, M. T., Carter, J. R., & Delgado, D. (2022). Gender differences in purpose in life: The mediation effect of altruism. *Journal of Humanistic Psychology*, 62(3), 352–376.
- Mask, M. B., Folk, D. P., & Heine, S. J. (2025). How sources of purpose predict meaning in life, happiness, and psychological richness, across cultures. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 1–11.

Week 8 Collaboration in Translational Research

March 9 & March 11

FOR MONDAY

- Burrow, A. L., Ratner, K., Porcelli, S., & Sumner, R. (2022). Does purpose grow here? Exploring 4-H as a context for cultivating youth purpose. *Journal of Adolescent Research*, 37(4), 471–500.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #2: IN-CLASS PARTNER CONVERSATION WITH PRYDE

- Elmore, K. C., Sumner, R., Tift, M., Forstrom, M. A., & Burrow, A. L. (2019). Building collaborative youth development research-practice partnerships through Cooperative Extension. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 105, 104413.
- Prepare one first-level and one second-level strategic question to ask PRYDE during class.

Week 9 Are Youth Purposeful?

March 16 & March 18

FOR MONDAY

- Ratner, K., Budesheim, E. F., Alexander, C. S., Klein, R. C., Leinenweber, S., Zhang, L., et al. (2025). Hurry up and wait: Developmental anxiety during the transition to adulthood. *Journal of Family Theory & Review*.
- Hill, P. L., & Burrow, A. L. (2021). Why youth are more purposeful than we think. *Child Development Perspectives*, 15(4), 281–286.

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Ratner, K., Xie, H., Zhu, G., Estevez, M., & Burrow, A. L. (2024). Trajectories and predictors of adolescent purpose development in self-driven learning. *Child Development*.

Cornerstone Project #2 (PRYDE) Organizational Analysis due 11:59pm

Week 10 Is Our Work Our Purpose?

March 23 & March 25

FOR MONDAY

- Weston, S. J., Hill, P. L., & Cardador, M. T. (2021). Working toward a purpose: Examining the cross-sectional and longitudinal effects of work characteristics on sense of purpose. *Journal of Personality*, 89(2), 244–257.
- Yemiscigil, A., Powdthavee, N., & Whillans, A. V. (2021). The effects of retirement on sense of purpose in life: Crisis or opportunity? *Psychological Science*, 32(11), 1856–1864.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #2 (PRYDE): IN-CLASS COLLECTIVE REFLECTION

Cornerstone Project #2 (PRYDE): Actionable contribution due 11:59pm

~ Spring Break ~

Week 11 Purpose and Social Relationships

April 6 & April 8

FOR MONDAY

- Pfund, G. N., Bono, T. J., & Hill, P. L. (2022). Purpose as a predictor of satisfaction across relationship domains during the first semester of university. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, 39(3), 570–591.
- Hill, P. L., Olaru, G., & Allemand, M. (2023). Do associations between sense of purpose, social support, and loneliness differ across the adult lifespan? *Psychology and Aging*, 38(4), 345.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #3: IN-CLASS PARTNER CONVERSATION WITH PURPOSE COMMONS

Week 12 How Stable Is Purpose?

April 13 & April 15

FOR MONDAY

- Pfund, G. N., Burrow, A. L., & Hill, P. L. (2024). Purpose in daily life: Considering within-person sense of purpose variability. *Journal of Research in Personality*, 109, 104473.
- Sutin, A. R., Luchetti, M., Stephan, Y., Stokes, J. E., & Terracciano, A. (2024). Purpose in life and stress: Momentary associations from a micro-longitudinal study. *Stress and Health*, 40(5), e3464.

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Pfund, G. N., Willroth, E. C., & English, T. (2025). Sense of purpose fluctuations in daily life. *Developmental Psychology*.
- Damon, W., Malin, H., & Colby, A. (2024). Purpose development in the context of higher education. *Applied Developmental Science*, 1–16.

Cornerstone Project #3 (Purpose Commons) Organizational Analysis due 11:59pm

Week 13 Is Purpose Findable?

April 20 & April 22

FOR MONDAY

- Burrow, A. L., & Rice, M. A. Is purpose findable? In P. Hill & A. L. Burrow (Eds.), *Purpose in Life as Ancient but Nascent: Perspectives from Psychology, Philosophy, and Human Development* (pp. 45–64). Cambridge University Press, 2025.
- Allemand, M., & Olaru, G. How to cultivate sense of purpose and life engagement: An integrative intervention framework. In P. Hill & A. L. Burrow (Eds.), *Purpose in Life as Ancient but Nascent* (pp. 158–184). Cambridge University Press, 2025.

FOR WEDNESDAY — CORNERSTONE PROJECT #3 (PURPOSE COMMONS): IN-CLASS COLLECTIVE REFLECTION

Cornerstone Project #3 (Purpose Commons): Actionable contribution due 11:59pm

Week 14 Open Questions in the Field of Purpose

April 27 & April 29

FOR MONDAY

- No preparation required

FOR WEDNESDAY

- Kashdan, T. B., Goodman, F. R., McKnight, P. E., Brown, B., & Rum, R. (2024). Purpose in life: A resolution on the definition, conceptual model, and optimal measurement. *American Psychologist*, 79(6), 838.

Week 15 Student Presentations

May 4

Final paper due 11:59pm, May 16, 2026